

IN CONTEXT

The English Reformation

Following Henry VIII's controversial establishment of the Protestant Church of England, there was a long period of sectarian turmoil, which characterized the English Reformation. Despite the Church's renunciation of papal authority, many people, including Henry's daughter Mary, clung to Catholic beliefs. As queen of England, Mary attempted to reverse her father's reforms. When she was succeeded by the Protestant Elizabeth I, Catholicism again became a covert religion.

Byrd was about 18 years old and a Protestant when Elizabeth came to the throne in 1558, but he converted to Catholicism in the 1570s, halfway through her reign. Perhaps because Elizabeth was more tolerant than some of her Puritan subjects, and a music-lover, too, Byrd did not suffer undue persecution, and he lived to enjoy the more liberal attitudes of her successor, James I, the son of Mary, Queen of Scots.



PORTRAIT OF ELIZABETH I BY NICHOLAS HILLIARD

William Byrd is thought to have been born in London in about 1540, although this date is disputed. What can be assumed is that